

Real estate

The screenshot shows the Magicbricks.com website. At the top, there's a navigation bar with links like 'Properties in India', 'Properties in Gulf', and 'Indiatimes | My Mail | Make MagicBricks your home'. Below this is a search bar with options for 'Buy' or 'Rent', and filters for 'Type' (Multistorey Apartment), 'Budget' (Min to Max), and 'City' (New Delhi). There are also links for 'City Specials' and 'Loans'. The main content area features a 'RAJ NAGAR EXTN.' advertisement, a 'Developer's Gallery' with logos for APTANA, KSL, and others, and a 'Featured Projects' section listing properties in Delhi & NCR, Chennai, and Bangalore. A large 'digit WEB AWARDS' banner is overlaid on the top right of the screenshot.

There is a sizeable number of real estate web sites in the Indian webspace. You have everything from full-fledged and heavily advertised portals such as **99acres.com**, to small listing services such as **anandproperties.com**. Even eBay has a real estate microsite, while there are specialised local services such as **realestate-chennai.com**. There is even a real estate off-shoot web site, **100nests.com**, that “helps you look at your home and associated real estate services in a more holistic manner”. Essentially, it offers valuations, neighbourhood networking and service providers

such as electricians. All this activity is even more surprising considering the real estate sector was one of the most affected in the recent downturn.

When we got down to dissecting property web sites, we first narrowed down to a short list of five. All the web sites follow a similar format for searching. “to buy” and “to rent” radio buttons are common with relevant fields that let

simple interface and easy navigation.

An interesting web site we came across and deserves a mention in terms of usability was **propertywala.com**. This web site has video walkthroughs on many topics and even a live chat with tech support that actually works. Among features, we looked at the ability to include photos in listings, EMI calculators, easy finance support, alerts and review options. Two web sites stood out in this regard – **magicbricks.com** and **99acres.com**.

Magicbricks.com shows listings in nearby locations. It has a separate section known as Rent Zone. It has Maps support and an auto suggest. On the other hand, **99acres.com** has a convenient ‘view similar

Find real estate classifieds

It turns out that free classified-ad web sites are among the most visited sites in India. In this domain Vizisense, an audience measurement platform, recently ranked **clickindia.com** as the top site. Classifieds web sites follow a similar navigation style. You can browse by category such as property, services, auto, etc., or by geographic location. The other sites in this space are **olx.in**, **quikr.com**, **locanto.in**, and **click.in**. A quick look at these sites will reveal the number of things you can find on them. You will find ads for sale, purchase, rentals and services related to homes, cars, two-wheelers. You'll find jobs, electronics, home appliances, education resources, apartments for rent, vacation cottages for rent and ads related to travel, dating, pets, and probably even a kitchen sink!



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you specify either type (residential or commercial) and its location. From this point on, the web sites differ in terms of refining search results, number of listings and added features. For instance, though **Indiaproperties.com** may have quite a decent number of listings, it lost out because the search refine function was very tacky. While others provided check boxes for refining by locality, advanced search in **indiaproperties.com** made you select localities manually. In terms of features, some have maps and photo support for listings, free SMS to contact sellers, while others let you chat live for more help.

While evaluating, we gave relevant weight to each of the attributes mentioned, as well as to the usability and navigation structure. Of the shortlisted candidates, **makaan.com** was the easiest to use with a

properties' button. It lets users contact multiple listings/advertisers at once. It also has a separate paying guest (PG) search on the main page and also offers a toll free support number.

But, aside of the usability fluff, what we must remember is that a good real estate web site is only as good as the number of property listings it brings to you. To evaluate listings we chose five locations spread across the country and within each location two or three popular and obscure localities. We fixed on a realistic price range, both for lease and buy. The greatest number of listings came from **magicbricks.com** and **99acres.com**, but the former was ahead by a considerable margin in most cases. Overall, **Magicbricks.com** emerged the winner thanks to its usability, number of listings and special features. **d**